



INDIVIDUAL QUESTIONS – INTRODUCTION

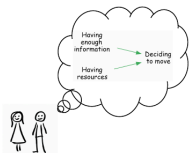
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Because the output is a structured network, we can apply a range of queries to explore the data. This gives us a library of **pre-existing approaches** to ask **practical questions** about the causal landscape described by the participants.

Here's a poster showing a few of the main questions.

Evaluation questions you can answer with causal mapping

Maybe you've heard of causal mapping...



But can you answer useful evaluation questions with it?

Here are a few examples!

What is causal mapping?

Non-causal Qualitative Data Analysis (QDA) version 1: code causality as a thematic approach

Non-causal QDA version 2: codes themes/concepts, with explicit causal connections between them

Causal QDA: code causal claims natively between pairs of codes

We code many "causal claims" across many sources. We use a codebook for cause/effect labels ("factors") which is either predefined or which we develop iteratively. The result is a table of causal links which can be visualised as a map



What is a causal map?

A causal map is a diagram in which boxes (which we call factors) are joined by directed links. A link means that someone claimed that one thing influenced or contributed to another.

A systems map usually tries to model reality. A causal map (or "causal concept map") usually tries to model how stakeholders think about reality. This approach has been used for 50 years (Axelrod, Eden, Ackerman...) in many disciplines, though not so much in evaluation.

DO use causal mapping when you...

- have many causal claims about links between many causal factors from many different sources
- want to organise all these causal claims
- are interested in differences between sources

DONT use causal mapping when you...

- are interested in a small number of specific high-stakes causal connections between a small number of causal factors, like the link between "taking the medicine" and "feeling better" (try Process Tracing instead)
- want a mathematical model, e.g. for predicting future states of the system (try Causal Loop Diagramming instead)
- would like to collaboratively develop a model of a problem or a plan for an intervention without worrying too much about who said what (try PFSM instead)

View individual pathways:
What is one respondent's experience?

Identify individual perspectives and narratives on project mechanisms. Get a picture of their worldview. Understand individual viewpoints to address specific concerns or leverage unique knowledge.

Show all the individual views together as an aggregated map or filter just to show one source or group.

View aggregated pathways:
What is the main story?

Causal mapping can help you identify and visualise common features of the causal stories told by most stakeholders. The bird's-eye view, it's a process which is creative (establishing your codebook) yet data-driven.

Can we find positive feedback loops within the network?

Compare groups:
Which links were mentioned more by some groups than others?

Query a causal map to compare link frequencies between groups and find links with surprising differences between groups, controlling for baseline frequencies. Above we see that these men mention a link between increased knowledge and health behaviour more frequently than these women.

Factor	Women	Men	Significant	Count
Increased knowledge	142	18	Yes	160
Health behaviour	18	142	Yes	160
Other factors	...	...	...	...

The frequency with which a link between factors is mentioned can, with caveats, be interpreted as a strength of the evidence for that link, contributing towards a final evaluative judgement against your rubrics.

Trace causal chains:
What are the direct and indirect consequences of one or more factors?

Trace chains of influence from a starting point like an intervention to a key outcome, or from an outcome back to drivers, revealing the step-by-step or branching logic described by the sources.

Beware the transitivity trap! Be careful when joining individual pathways into longer causal claims. If they come from different sources in different contexts. You can use "source tracing" to mitigate this but can be quite tricky to do. You need patience, or specialised software.

Identify unexpected elements:
What are the emerging factors?

If you code your transcripts or documents without reference to any 'official' codebook or theory of change, you can discover how your sources conceive of the key causal factors and the words they use to describe them. It's useful for identifying unexpected or evolving elements in a project's ecosystem and to understand how different factors combine and interact in ways you might not have anticipated.

Impact pathways:
What is the evidence that the intervention influenced key outcomes?

Causal mapping doesn't give you 'The Answer', but is a way of organising evidence to help you make final evaluation judgements and causal inferences.

- Compare causal maps with your theory of change
- Compare the strength of evidence for different pathways and what this means for your rubrics
- Use original quotes to understand people's experiences

Causal mapping helps to organise the evidence. The judgement is still yours.

Free app to create and analyse causal maps

Download the app

Steve Powell
Fiona Remnant

Come and talk to us about causal mapping!

Get all resources

Full guide to causal mapping

See also

- Formatting your map for what you want to show for the visualisation side.
- Vignettes for textual outputs.

PAGES IN THIS CHAPTER

- Individual views – How does the system work according to individual sources ?
- Summarising – How do the sources claim that the system works, in summary ?
- Vignettes – What is a typical source and what is their story ?
- What are the narratives behind a specific link ?
- Which factors and links were most frequently mentioned ?

-  **Which factors and links are mentioned by the most sources ?**
-  **Main outcomes. Which factors are mentioned most often as outcomes ?**
-  **Main drivers. Which factors are mentioned most often as drivers ?**
-  **Splitting by groups. Are different groups involved in different ways ?**
-  **Comparing groups – What factors or links were mentioned more by some groups than others, in the same map ?**
-  **Identifying groups – Are there different subgroups within the data ?**
-  **What are the emerging or unexpected factors ?**
-  **Does the evidence support your theory of change ?**
-  **Assessing systems change**
-  **Sentiment – Which changes are perceived as most positive or negative ?**
-  **Sentiment discrepancy – Which factors do sources most disagree about ?**
-  **Focusing on specific factors. What influences and outcomes are connected to a specific factor ?**
-  **Looking downstream. What are the direct and indirect consequences of one or more factors ?**
-  **Looking upstream. What are the direct and indirect influences on one or more factors ?**
-  **Path tracing – How do one or more causes affect one or more effects, including indirect pathways ?**
-  **Source tracing – What are the consequences of one or more factors, looking only at stories told in their entirety by individual sources ?**
-  **Robustness – How robust is the evidence for that X influences Y ?**
-  **Counting and comparing influences**

 **Properties of the causal map – Which factors are reported as being causally central or causally peripheral ?**

 **Properties of the causal map – What is the overall structure of the network ?**

 **Properties of the causal map – Are there leverage points ?**

 **Properties of the causal map – Are there feedback loops ?**

 **Combining questions**

 **Tribes. The most relevantly different subgroups in your data (by causal story)**

 **Showing group data as custom link labels on the map with optional significance test**

 **Names of tables and fields**

 **Hierarchical coding**
